
EXPLANATORY MEMORANDUM

PROPOSED STATEMENTS ON STANDARDS FOR CONTINUING PROFESSIONAL EDUCATION (CPE) PROGRAMS

August 1, 2026

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Explanatory Memorandum

Introduction

The Statement on Standards for Continuing Professional Education (CPE) Programs (*Standards*) is published jointly by the American Institute of Certified Public Accountants (AICPA) and the National Association of State Boards of Accountancy (NASBA) to provide a framework for the development, presentation, measurement, and reporting of CPE programs.

The *Standards* are periodically reviewed in their entirety by the CPE Standards Working Group (Working Group). The Working Group is comprised of thirteen (13) members representing various stakeholders in CPE including state boards of accountancy, state societies, educators, CPE providers and the AICPA. If the Working Group determines that revisions or modifications are required, then the Working Group will make its recommendation to NASBA's CPE Committee (CPE Committee), which in turn makes recommendations to the Joint AICPA/NASBA CPE Standards Committee (Joint Committee). The Joint Committee will then make its recommendation to the respective AICPA and NASBA Boards of Directors.

The *Standards* are intended to be an "evergreen" document. The *Standards* are reviewed and evaluated every two years from the effective date of the last revision to the document. The *Standards* were last revised with an effective date of January 1, 2024.

Background

Why the Proposed *Standards* Have Been Developed

During the most recent revision cycle, the Working Group, a sub-committee of NASBA's CPE Committee, considered the advancements in technology and learning platforms, the transformative impact of technology-assisted learning and other innovations in learning and learning modalities that seem to be blurring the lines of how the instructional delivery methods for CPE programs are currently defined in the *Standards*.

The Working Group believed that it was time to holistically reconsider the instructional delivery methods and challenge what those might be in the future. In addition to considering the items noted above, the Working Group addressed challenges inherent in the current delivery methods of the *Standards*. The Working Group also created strategies for building flexibility to accommodate future innovations in learning and the design of professional education.

Overarching Principles

The overall direction of the project was influenced by the purview of the state boards of accountancy, which is focused on formal CPE learning programs that are measurable and verifiable. Seven principles of formal CPE learning programs were defined as the framework for the development, presentation, measurement, and reporting of CPE programs. The seven principles are:

1. Learning Objectives
2. Quality of CPE Program
3. Participant Engagement
4. CPE Program Completion Verification
5. CPE Program Measurement
6. Participant Communication
7. Required Documentation of CPE Programs

The proposed *Standards* (Proposal) have been reorganized in sections (instead of the current standards/paragraphs format) by the seven principles to simplify the presentation of the *Standards* and improve readability. The Proposal has expanded the “principles” based approach to help create flexibility to accommodate future changes and innovations in learning. (CPE programs that qualify for CPE credit under the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* will continue to qualify for CPE credit under the Proposal.)

Summary of Significant Changes in the Proposed *Standards*

- Introduction – The Introduction and Preamble from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* have been revised and combined into the Introduction in the Proposal. Most concepts have been retained.
- Definitions – Renamed from Article I in the extant 2024 version to Section 1 in the Proposal. Updates to definitions to reflect proposed changes and modification throughout the document.
- Article II – General Guidelines for CPAs from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* has been removed. Article II was historically included in the *Standards* to explain overall guidelines and requirements of CPE for CPAs to CPE program providers. It was not intended to be a resource to CPAs regarding specific jurisdiction CPE requirements. Certain information from paragraph 2.1, Professional Competence, was incorporated into the Introduction of the Proposal. In the spirit of simplifying and improving the readability of the *Standards*, the rest of extant Article II has been removed from the Proposal.
- Article III – Standards for CPE Programs has been reformatted to Section 2 – General Standards in the Proposal. This section now sets out the formal learning programs and learning activities which qualify for CPE under the *Standards*: formal learning programs; instructor/speaker activities; author/developer activities; and content reviewer activities. [Note: References to independent study and college and university credit from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* have been removed from the Proposal and participants directed to refer to their State board of accountancy for guidance on this type of credit. State boards of accountancy rules and regulations typically include specific requirements regarding the acceptance of college and university credit. Only approximately fourteen (14) out of the 55 state boards of accountancy accept CPE credit for independent study programs and all 14 boards require that any independent study program be approved by the board in advance. Therefore, those areas do not seem meaningful to include in the Proposal.]
- Paragraph 2.02.1 of Section 2 – General Standards further explains that formal learning

programs are defined within the Proposal as group programs, self study programs, or blended learning programs. The Proposal provides the types of programs that could qualify as a group program, corresponding to programs defined as Group Live and Group Internet-Based programs from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards*. Self study programs are described as, but not limited to, traditional on-demand learning programs, adaptive learning programs, and nano learning programs. The description of blended learning programs is unchanged from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards*.

- Section 3 – Standards for Learning Objectives has been carried forward from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* (Standard No. 2 and No. 3).
- Section 4 – Standards for Quality of CPE Program has been carried forward from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* with some minor edits (Standard No. 4, No.5, No. 13, No. 14, No. 15, and No. 9 paragraph S9-07).
- Section 5 – Standards for Participant Engagement carries forward the concept of an element of engagement for Group Live programs for the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* (Standard No.7). However, it expands the requirement for learning engagement to all types of formal CPE programs and includes examples for group programs, self study programs, and blended learning programs.
- Paragraph 5.01.2.2 of Section 5 – Standards for Participant Engagement provides guidance for the use of review questions as participant engagement in self study programs. The Proposal includes a change in the requirements for feedback on review questions to move away from requiring evaluative feedback for each incorrect answer and reinforcement feedback for the correct answer. Input from CPE Program sponsors indicates that these feedback requirements are the most time-consuming and difficult requirements to comply for self study programs in the extant 2024 version of the *Standards*. Additionally, many platforms currently available for the design and development of self study programs have limitations providing feedback for review questions.

The Proposal still requires feedback to be provided for review questions and other content reinforcement tools but allows for more principles-based feedback. The Proposal provides guidance that the objective of the feedback is to reinforce understanding, highlight knowledge gaps and provide additional resources for learning comprehension. Section 6 – Standards for CPE Program Completion Verification carries forward Standard 16 paragraph S16-02 from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards*. Paragraph 6.01.1 of the Proposal emphasizes that for group programs, program completion verification methods should account for both individual presence and the time duration of such presence to address significant compliance issues that currently exist with Registry sponsors. The Proposal allows the sponsor to choose a completion verification method for group programs and provides examples. Completion verification for self study programs is mostly carried forward from the extant 2024 versions of the *Standards* (Standard No. 9 paragraphs S9-04 and S9-05 and Standard 10 paragraphs S10-01 and S10-02). Completion verification for blended learning programs is carried forward from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* (Standard No. 11 paragraphs S11-02 through S11-03).

- Section 7 – Standards for CPE Program Measurement proposes changes to the amount of CPE credit that can be earned initially for group programs and self study programs. The Proposal allows for group program credit to be earned initially as one-half credit or one

full credit. The Proposal also allows for self study program credit to be earned in one-fifth or one-half credit initially. If one-fifth credit is earned initially, it permits additional credit to be earned in one-fifth increments.

There are state boards of accountancy that currently permit CPE credits to be earned in these initial increments for group and self study programs. Emphasis has been included in the Proposal that rules and regulations of state boards of accountancy may differ on the acceptable increments of CPE credit and CPE program sponsors should comply with those rules in awarding CPE credit.

The proposed change in self study CPE increments is intended to provide greater flexibility for shorter learning activities and to lay the foundation for future simplification within the *Standards*. As the state boards of accountancy evaluate and adopt these increments over time, the distinction between nano learning and traditional self study learning programs may become less necessary.

At this time, nano learning continues to be retained as a distinct category within the Standards because many state boards of accountancy currently recognize nano learning credits as a separate CPE delivery method. Retaining nano learning as a delivery method helps ensure continuity with existing regulatory frameworks and current sponsor practices while allowing the Standards to evolve toward a more streamlined structure in future revisions.

The guidance for the minimum required number of review questions and qualified assessment questions for self study programs has been expanded and revised based on the proposed changes. See paragraphs 5.01.2.1 and 6.01.2.

- Section 7 – Standards for CPE Program Measurement - In the spirit of simplifying and improving the readability of the *Standards*, the measurement methodology paragraphs for traditional on-demand self study programs and adaptive learning programs from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* have been combined with specific call-out for differences in the sample sizes for pilot testing and the use of an average of all potential learning paths for the word count formula. Section 7 also permits the use of participant actual completion time for adaptive learning if the learning platform or technology can track individual participant completion time.
- Section 7 – Standards for CPE Program Measurement carries forward the CPE credit determination methodologies for nano learning and blended learning programs for the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* (Standard No. 18 and No. 19). Section 7 also carries forward the CPE credit measurement guidance for instructor/speakers; author/developers; and content reviewers from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* (Standard No. 20, No. 21, and No. 22).
- Section 8 – Standards for Participant Communication carries forward the participant communication requirements and guidance from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* (Standard No. 12 and language from Standard 16 paragraph S16-03).
- Section 9 – Standards for Required Documentation of CPE Programs carries forward the guidance from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* for the certificate of completion (Standard No. 23). The Proposal reorganizes the guidance from the extant 2024 version of the *Standards* and includes specific requirements with examples of documentation for each type of formal CPE learning program: group programs, self study programs and blended learning programs.

Effective Date

August 1, 2026

Unless otherwise established by state licensing bodies or other professional organizations, these Standards are to be effective as follows:

1. For group programs or self study programs already existing as of July 31, 2026, the changes will need to be in effect by November 1, 2028.
2. For group and self study programs in development and/or being published for the first time, the changes will be effective March 1, 2027.
3. For initial or additional delivery method applications for group programs or self study, the changes will be effective August 1, 2026.